

Which of the following scenarios best illustrates role exit?

- ☐ A. A physician instructor struggles to balance the demands of patient care and student instruction. [1%]
- ☐ B. A physician reduces her patient load so she can attend more of her children's school events. [6%]
- ✓ ☒ C. A nurse practitioner retires from a long career at a busy hospital to travel with her spouse. [90%]
- ☐ D. A medical student who has been diagnosed with the flu is exempt from classes for one week. [1%]

Correct

90% answered correctly

Explanation:

Elements of social interaction: Roles	
Role strain	- Competing expectations within a single role create tension - eg, a student struggles to find enough time to complete homework (expectation 1) & attend student government meetings (expectation 2)
Role conflict	- Competing expectations for two or more roles create tension - eg, a student (role 1) who is employed part-time (role 2) struggles to find enough time to complete homework & work late hours
Role exit	- Individual disengages from a social role, often replacing it with a new social role - eg, a college student (old role) graduates & begins full-time employment (new role)

Social roles refer to an individual's expected behavior in social situations. For example, a police officer's role in society is to enforce the law; when a crime occurs, others expect the police officer to act.

Role strain occurs when a **single role** involves multiple competing expectations, which produce **tension**. For example, a physician instructor who struggles to balance patient care and student instruction (ie, two expectations of the physician instructor role) is illustrating role strain (**Choice A**).

Role conflict occurs when **two or more roles** simultaneously held by an individual compete, producing **tension**. For example, a physician who reduces her patient load because she feels tension between her responsibilities to her patients (ie, physician role) and to her children (ie, mother role) is illustrating role conflict (**Choice B**).

Role exit is the process by which an individual **disengages** from a defined social **role**; role exit may be preceded by role strain and/or role conflict. A nurse practitioner who retires from a long career at a busy hospital to travel with her spouse is disengaging from her occupational role and starting a new role as a retiree, which illustrates role exit.

(**Choice D**) According to sick role theory, illness, which causes disruption to expected social obligations (eg, attending classes) and is therefore a form of deviance, is socially acceptable in certain circumstances (ie, sick person seeks and complies with treatment). A medical student who is *temporarily exempt* from classes due to the flu is illustrating the sick role, not role exit.

Educational objective:

Social roles define how people are expected to behave in social situations. Competing expectations of a single role (role strain) or multiple roles (role conflict) may lead to role exit, the process of disengaging from an existing role.

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